

LE7547: Inner Journey of a Leader

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Cloud Final Paper

Introduction

In this paper, I will examine the four ways we need to heal and grow in order to become the image-bearers of Christ that God intended for us. You see, we were intended to be emotionally healthy and whole; we were not intended to have mental problems and want to suicide.

In this book, there are countless examples of people who have reached the end of the rope, and want to suicide. They cannot solve their problems. Some of these people are even ministers. And what is the core summarizing issue that all of these people have? They have some emotional healing that they need to do - not just spiritual.

You see, the spiritual is important, but the emotional is important as well. And as we'll see in this paper and book, we cannot simply just read the Bible to solve all our problems. Our lives consist of emotions and people and even mental health.

By bonding with others, and understanding our realistic self, and being an adult, and setting boundaries, we can grow into the image-bearer of God that Jesus intended.

Bonding

The chapter on bonding starts off with a story of a lady who wants to suicide. ““You kept me alive. That’s hurt enough,’ she said. Cut off from divine and human contact, Tara lived in an earthly hell.” (Cloud, 56).

What was Tara’s problem? One may think it is a problem of too much stress, too much difficulty in life, but the author points to a single source of problem - a lack of bonding.

Bonding is defined as “emotional attachment to another person” (Cloud, 57). It’s when you can “share their deepest thoughts, dreams, and feelings with each other with no fear that they will be rejected by the other person” (Cloud, 57).

God created us to have this desire for bonding in us. Cloud says, we “hunger for relationship—for relationship with him [God]” (58).

And he says that, “Without such connectedness to God and others” (58), we are going to snuggle and lack happiness.

As you can see, we all need bonding. We want to be connected to God and with others. We want someone to share our thoughts and someone we can share our thoughts with. We want to be loved and cared for, and surprisingly, we all want to love others and care for others.

We want to give and take. This leads to a surprising fact: we are not just takers, we are givers as well.

I am reminded of a parable that is Chinese in origin. In heaven, there are large chopsticks and a big circle table. The people feed the person across the table because the chopsticks are large. However, in hell, everyone’s trying to feed their own selves with their chopsticks and so no one is fed.

The moral of the story is: we are meant to love one other and receive love. And when this is broken, there is a dramatic danger in our emotional health.

As we can see in the case of Tara, what is worse than getting punched in the face is emotional isolation. Without someone to talk to, and without people to be with, Tara was drowning by herself and no one was there to save her. And she thus, wanted to go to the very end of the rope and suicide.

You see, we all need to be connected. Without connection we risk danger. It's not just something we want, it's something we *need*. It's like water or food. And as we'll see later in the paper soon, infants show this need very well.

“Love comes from God. Everyone who loves has been born of God and knows God” (1 John 4:7).

“We begin to bond naturally as infants” (63). Infants come out of the womb, from which they had comfort and closeness with the mother. And when they come out, they are hit with bright light that is piercing, and they are isolated from everything. They don't know what is going on and there is chaos. But when the mother starts loving the infant, the infant relaxes and starts to feel love and comfort. “He turns toward his mother for warmth, for food, and for love” (63).

And the infant depends on the mother for psychological comfort and love. He constantly goes to her when he needs her and needs comfort.

But later on, “he also is able to love the absent one, whom he has internalized” (64). What this means is that the baby is able to feel the psychological and emotional comfort even when the mother is not there.

But I want to emphasize, this emotional independence and health is only developed if the baby first experiences the emotional dependence and closeness first! You see, if the baby doesn't experience love from the beginning, for the rest of his life he will be seeking for love. This shows the crucial importance of bonding and how many problems we have in the future of our lives are due to lack of bonding when we were young. Cloud wants to teach us how to bond and

receive that love and heal if we did not receive that bonding when we were younger because of a crazy family.

"If an infant bonds well in her first year of life, in the second year, she begins to learn some independence" (65).

And Cloud says that bonding is important to stave off a number of illnesses. "One's ability to recover from an entire range of physical illness" is determined by how much one has bonding in their lives.

And I want to emphasize that Cloud is saying that we need bonding when we are infants and young and in the developmental stages; but we also need bonding when we are older and in every stage of our lives.

For example, the "nature of a patient's emotional ties drastically affects whether or not this patient will get heart disease" (66).

"When we are isolated, we are slowly dying" (66).

There was a patient who said to Cloud, "'It doesn't do any good to pray or read my Bible,' he confessed. 'It's not relieving my tension one bit'" (67). Cloud is saying that typical, trite responses that faith-people give may not solve the problems of emotional health. You see, reading the Bible is good, but if you have emotional problems, you need bonding, not a bible verse. And eventually, a person says that he needs his mother:

"I need my mother inside of me! She's supposed to live on the inside where she can't get away!" (68)

Cloud reminds us of the bible verse: "For whoever does not love their brother or sister, whom they have seen, cannot love God, whom they have not seen" (1 John 4:20). We must

remember that God wants us to love each other, and this is necessary to being a good Christian. If you say you are Christian and love God, but you have trouble or cannot love your neighbor, this is not a good sign. People need love. This verse is telling us that our neighbor needs our love and that being Christian means that we love them.

Cloud reminds us of: “I desire compassion, and not a sacrifice” (Bible).

Boundaries

The chapter starts with a story of man who is a minister, and he’s burned out. He’s doing all sorts of things, saying yes to everything and everyone, but he’s saying no to himself. Essentially, he is a yes-man. What’s happening is that he has no boundaries.

The result? “The rest of his ministry suffered. He forgot appointments he had made. He began to resent the church for demanding so much of him without giving him the recognition he deserved.” (109). And for his wife, “he ‘gladly’ agreed to do what pleased her” (110).

What’s happening is that he is lacking control of himself. He is not able to guard his own desires and wants and stand up for himself and push out the other things that conflict with himself and those things regarding himself. He lets those requests into his boundary line, and he mixes and minces and thus, he cannot maintain his own individuality.

Cloud says that ultimately, boundaries “say what we are and what we are not, what we will choose and what we will not choose” (110).

People without boundaries “truly cannot tell where they end and someone else begins, and thus they suffer from lack of purpose, powerlessness, panic, identity loss, eating disorders, depression, irresponsibility, and a whole host of problems” (111).

Another story is a Thanksgiving dinner. A relative says that she could never offend her mother-in-law. “‘But that would make her very angry,’ Sandy replied. ‘I could never do that. It’s mean’” (111). But, I think what Cloud is saying is that when we need to conflict and make a hard decision, we need to say things that can sound *mean*, but actually get our point across. The alternative is not to say our opinion and just let something happen that we don’t want; and that’s something we cannot let pass.

And so Cloud points out an important dilemma: “But how do we establish an attachment and still remain an individual?” (111). I understand this dilemma: we want to be connected, but by being connected, we don’t want to be pulled in every direction and thus lose our identity or our boundaries. We want the best of both worlds. So what’s the solution?

Cloud doesn’t give a clear-cut solution, but I believe the solution is simply, we need to bond and love others, but try to keep boundaries. We need to juggle all these things and try to maintain balance.

Cloud says that God also has boundaries. He says things that he loves and seven or eight things that are an abomination to him. “What he wants and what he does not want, what he thinks about things and what he does—all of these things define the boundaries of who he is” (112).

Cloud says that human biology seems to support that we need boundaries as well. “Our body has physical boundaries that define who we are. The skin is the clearest picture of a boundary that exists for a person. If we open our mouths, we can let in a nourishing glass of milk.” (116).

Cloud says that we can stand up for our own opinions. “As we mature, we need to take more and more responsibility for making sure our opinions are ours and not someone else’s. We choose them” (117). This is important because we need to setup boundaries and enforce them; and as we mature, we gain the confidence to setup these boundaries.

I believe that when we are young, we have no confidence and we let people into our personal zones and we lose our identity. But as we mature, our brain chemicals balance, and we are able to shape and become firm in our identity and person. “we can make sure that what we have inside our property line is what we want” (117).

Sorting Out Good and Bad

Cloud starts off by talking about a story. Then he says, “The world around us is good and bad. The people around us are good and bad. We are good and bad” (204).

It’s a profound truth. What Cloud is going to point out is that we are trying to be perfect and good, and trying to kick out the bad. We want to separate from the bad. But the truth is, we are always going to be living in a world that is both good and bad, and we ourselves will always be both good and bad.

Therefore, he will conclude, we need to accept ourselves - even our bad selves.

He says, “Our natural tendency is to try to resolve the problem of good and evil by keeping the good and the bad separated” (204). Our unwillingness to accept the bad is our problem. And he gives an example of a person with OCD who cannot accept the bad part of himself. The reason why he has obsessive thoughts is because he cannot accept the bad thoughts and thus they spiral out of control.

This separation of ourselves between good and bad “creates a split in our experience of ourselves” (204). It leads to us to have an “inability to tolerate badness, weakness, and failure in ourselves. We require perfection.” (204).

The problem with compartmentalizing ourselves good and bad is that there will always be a hidden enemy of badness that is around. He will hide and try to be hidden and locked under the bed, but he will come out at the worst times and he will always survive and maybe even grow bigger. By accepting this enemy, we neutralize the threat, and we are able to reconcile and be at peace.

It’s so common for people to “withdraw from the church, group, or job, only to move to another imperfect and disappointing situation, or we idealize situations in a way that blinds us to their bad points” (204). What he’s saying is that people cannot accept the bad and only want the good, and so when their church causes some problems, they move to a different church, and they can never settle.

Cloud says, we need to be able to comfortably live with the bad because there will always be bad - this world is precisely that - good and bad.

But why do we have a problem with dealing with the bad? It’s because it was never supposed to be this way. Adam and Eve were created in a perfectly good world. “We were not prepared to live in an imperfect world” (205).

“We were made for perfect relationship with perfect people; instead, the people with whom we find ourselves invariably hurt us” (205). It’s so hard to accept the fact that our authority figures and our role models and even our trusted people can hurt us. They may actually

have bad intentions and sin. But we must accept the fact that all people are not perfect, and instead of hating them, we need to forgive them and love them.

If we never accept the bad, “we can’t have a consistent relationship with ourselves, others, or the world around us” (206). For example, the situation when you “played a rotten game and felt enormous hatred for yourself” (206). We should love ourselves even when we make mistakes or play a terrible game.

We can all imagine our perfect and ideal self. It is everything we can possibly wish for. But the only problem is: it is not real.

“The real self is the one that we truly are, not the one we wish to be” (208).

“But I am unspiritual, sold as a slave to sin” (Rom. 7:14).

“In addition to our sinful aspects, we are weak” (209).

What we see is the our real self is not actually perfect - it is not ideal. To be able to actually make reality better, we need to deal with our real self. And our real self will always be a sinner.

When we find out that we have a sinful flesh attached to us, we have two options: a “judgmental vs accepting tone” (211). We can judge and condemn ourselves, or we can love and accept ourselves. We can use “shame, guilt, hiding, denial, splitting, and other defenses to hide the real self,” or have a “loving and accepting tone toward our real self, [where] there is hope for transformation” (211).

The true answer is: acceptance. We can confess what is wrong. “To demand perfection will ruin our life. The God-fearing person avoids both legalism and license and leads a balanced life.” (212).

And I find this to be very true. We need to take control of our sinful flesh, but at the same time we need to let it be and allow it to sin to a degree. We should never sin willingly, but we should understand that we will sin. And sin we must.

Adulthood

Cloud starts of the adulthood section by giving a story about a woman who “worried most about what other people thought of her” (251). You see, her problem was that she was not commanding her ground. She was not creating boundaries. She was not using her authority as an adult to do what she wanted to do and command her life. She was following and pleasing everyone, just like a baby would do for others.

We should not be people pleasers, we should have a healthy command of self-interest and other-centered-interest. We should do what we want, and we should have opinions.

Reaching this level of confidence is the process of growing up and becoming an adult. It is like first being “being born a little person” in a big world (252). We are “given the task of becoming a big person over time” (252).

The author defines an adult as people who “have the power or right to give commands, enforce obedience, take action, or make final decisions” (252). They have this right intrinsically because they are adults. For example, they have “authority over children because they are parents” (253).

The beautiful thing is that, “a final part of being an authority is to be able to give up rights and serve others in submission” (253). A child can pronounce judgment and command anything he wants, but it takes a truly strong, humble servant to be able to lay down his rights and be crucified and serve the sheep.

The process to reach this level of adulthood is not easy. “Many forces and circumstances interfere with the process” of growing up (253).

Becoming an adult means, “taking on more and more power and responsibility...including developing a career, engaging in sexuality, establishing mutual friendships, treating other adults as peers, and having opinions” (253).

And the beginning of growing

“begins with bonding, having boundaries and separateness, and resolving good and bad, but ultimately has to do with coming out from under the one-down relationship that a child has to parents and other adults and coming into an equal standing as an adult on his or her own” (253-254).

And in the end, “we are supposed to become equal with other adults” (254).

I think it’s a powerful thing to say that we need to reach adulthood and be equal with other adults. It’s like an amateur football player reaching pro level. We need to fight and grow and reach that level of importance and ability. Adulthood is not just a physical growth, but a spiritual and emotional growth.

And why do we need to be adults? Can’t we all just be children?

We need to be adults because we are told to take dominion of the world and of ourselves. If we don’t become adults, we cannot control and manage ourselves, and we will have anxiety all the time like the person in the beginning of this section.

We need to be adults so that we can strongly share the gospel to a dark world as well.

Personal Assessment

I think that we all need emotional health. And counseling is so important to get things straightened and to get aware of our needs and what we need in order to heal.

Not many people have the luxury to focus on their emotional health - they simply go through life, drifting, and hurting, and having pains and disasters that they don't understand and cannot control.

They are busy making money, or even doing ministry, and they cannot focus on the inner life of a leader.

I personally want to be completely healed before I start ministry because that would honor God and that would be happy for me.

The book talks of how we need boundaries to choose what we want to do, and we need to command our lives as adults. I want to command my life so that I can be happy and put my emotional and spiritual health first. "God first," so the saying goes; and that includes my emotional and spiritual health relative to God and to others.

Plans for Future Growth

I believe that I need learn how to become co-dependent on others. I am seeking too much independence, and I need to be part of a church and community of people. But it is interesting, because this independence may be a good fit for a professor and researcher rather than a pastor.

I don't know whether I'll be a pastor or a professor, but I seek the Lord's will.

I want to be able to grow as an adult so that I can have a family and start my ministry. I think it is very difficult to be isolated and single for the whole of life.

Conclusion

In conclusion, there are four areas in which we need to grow and heal in order to become a fully-functioning, emotionally healthy person.

I believe I key-theme in this class is to be emotionally-healthy. Spiritual health is important, but that is covered in the many classes on theology that we have at the seminary. Emotional health and the Inner Journey of a Leader begins with the growth and healing on the inside.

Without being emotionally healthy, there will be a variety and myriad number of problems that will sprout out in my life. Thus, from the beginning, I need to focus on my life with God and with others, especially family.

Then, when I am fully healed and ready to go, I can minister to the world and be successful.

Bibliography

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